

Stellarocq: Machine-Checked Certificates for Stellarator Equilibria

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Abstract

A stellarator equilibrium code ends its run with a file of floating-point Fourier coefficients, and what that file establishes about the magnetic field is judged by the code's own convergence metrics. Stellarocq states it as machine-checked theorems. It reconstructs the field from the exact numbers of a VMEC++ output file by VMEC's half-grid interpolation, and a Rocq development proves that the residual it evaluates is $\mu_0(\mathbf{J} \times \mathbf{B} - \nabla p)$ of that field and that the field's Jacobian and metric differ from VMEC's own by exact terms of second order in the radial step. Each claim, a bound, a Fourier harmonic, a flux-surface integral or a Mercier term, is decided by a checker extracted from a proof that a passing verdict implies it. On manufactured problems the certificates show the half-grid rule converging at second order, with the error known to a relative 10^{-12} . On VMEC++ equilibria they show a force harmonic at a rational surface falling only as the square root of the radial step, the signature of a current sheet; a free-boundary pressure jump that radial refinement barely reduces, for every vacuum field between the answers of two independent solvers; and a Mercier criterion whose sign at coarse resolution depends on how the radial derivatives are taken. The development proves both of Landreman's families of exact three-dimensional equilibria to be ideal-MHD equilibria, and against one of them VMEC++'s field converges at about second order away from the axis. On W7-X the certified force is set by the Fourier truncation, not the radial grid.

1 Introduction

The Variational Moments Equilibrium Code (VMC) [1, 2] computes three-dimensional ideal-MHD equilibria with nested flux surfaces by minimizing the plasma energy over Fourier representations of the surfaces. It and its reimplementations VMEC++ [3, 4] sit at the centre of stellarator design and optimization. A run ends with a *wout* file: Fourier coefficients of the surfaces on a radial grid, profiles, and derived quantities such as the Mercier stability terms, all in binary64 floating point.

What such a file establishes about the field it describes is judged by convergence metrics internal to the solver and by diagnostics recomputed in floating point, and those judgements can mislead in ways the file does not show. The normalized force residual a run drives below 10^{-12} concerns the Fourier harmonics the solver retains, while the force of the field the file defines can stay near a percent of B^2 . A Mercier term computed from radial differences of the file's profiles can change sign when the differences are taken another way. A rational surface can carry a current sheet that the solution resolves more slowly than anything else as the radial grid is refined. Each of these is a statement about the field the file defines, and each can be decided exactly.

Stellarocq decides them as theorems. The object of every statement is the field reconstructed from the exact numbers in the file by the solver's own interpolation of its surface coefficients, and the development proves how the Jacobian and metric of that field differ from the ones the solver forms. A claim about that field is decided by a checking function written in Rocq [5], proven to imply the claim when it returns `true`, and extracted to OCaml [6]; real-number semantics and

interval arithmetic come from Coquelicot [7], Floccq [8] and CoqInterval [9]. A certificate carries the file's numbers and the claimed bounds, so anyone can check it again with the released checker.

The development contributes four things. It proves that the residual it evaluates is the ideal-MHD force of the reconstructed field, and how that field's Jacobian and metric differ from the ones VMEC forms (Section 2). It supplies checking functions, extracted from Rocq with their soundness theorems, for bounds at points and over cells, discrete Fourier harmonics, flux-surface integrals, the Mercier criterion and the existence of discrete solutions (Section 3). It proves that both of Landreman's families of explicit three-dimensional fields [58] are ideal-MHD equilibria, so that a solver's distance from them is a true error. And it applies the checkers to VMEC++ (Section 4).

The applications give six findings. On manufactured problems the half-grid rule converges at second order, with the error known to a relative 10^{-12} , and the stability constant its convergence theorem assumes is measured to converge. On a rational surface a harmonic of the force falls only as the square root of the radial step, while the non-resonant harmonics fall as its square. At the free boundary the pressure jump falls by factors of only 1.05 to 1.14 per doubling of the surfaces, for every vacuum field between the answers of two independent solvers. At coarse resolution the certified Mercier criterion takes either sign, depending on how the radial derivatives are taken. Against Landreman's sheared equilibrium VMEC++'s field converges at about second order away from the axis, and against his equilibrium with $\iota = 2$ it does not converge. On W7-X the certified force is set by the Fourier truncation and not by the radial grid. Section 5 draws the consequences for users of VMEC. The certified values are regression tests on a branch of VMEC++ [28], Stellarocq's differential testing added tests of invariances and of the energy's gradient to VMEC++, and VMEC++'s continuous integration now measures its solutions against the exact equilibria [33].

2 The certified object

Reconstruction. VMEC keeps the surface coefficients of R and Z on the full radial grid $s_j = jh$ and the stream function λ , the rotational transform ι and every field quantity on the half grid $s_{j+1/2}$. Stellarocq's `Physics.v` writes the rule that connects them. On a half point s_h between nodes a and b , a coefficient of even poloidal mode number is the mean of its two node values and one of odd mode number is averaged with the $\sqrt{s}$ weight VMEC folds into its Jacobian,

$$c_k(s_h) = \frac{1}{2}(c_k(a) + c_k(b)) \quad (m_k \text{ even}), \quad c_k(s_h) = \frac{1}{2}\sqrt{s_h} \left(\frac{c_k(a)}{\sqrt{s_a}} + \frac{c_k(b)}{\sqrt{s_b}} \right) \quad (m_k \text{ odd}), \quad (1)$$

with radial derivatives the matching difference quotients and angular derivatives exact derivatives of the series $R = \sum_k c_k \cos(m_k u - n_k v)$, $Z = \sum_k z_k \sin(m_k u - n_k v)$. The half-grid λ and ι are the file's own, Φ' is constant, and the pressure is the input's profile. For statements at an arbitrary radius each coefficient of R and Z is the cubic Hermite interpolant of its half-point values and slopes, which agrees with the half-grid rule at the half points; λ follows the same parity rule linearly between half points, and ι is linear there.

Field and residual. With $\sqrt{g} = R(R_u Z_s - R_s Z_u)$, the field is $B^u = \Phi'(\iota - \lambda_v)/\sqrt{g}$, $B^v = \Phi'(1 + \lambda_u)/\sqrt{g}$, its covariant components are $B_i = g_{iu} B^u + g_{iv} B^v$, and $\mu_0 \sqrt{g} J^s = \partial_u B_v - \partial_v B_u$. The residual of $\mathbf{J} \times \mathbf{B} = \nabla p$ has the components

$$r_u = -\mu_0 \sqrt{g} J^s B^v, \quad r_v = \mu_0 \sqrt{g} J^s B^u, \quad r_s = (\partial_v B_s - \partial_s B_v) B^v - (\partial_s B_u - \partial_u B_s) B^u - \mu_0 \frac{dp}{ds}, \quad (2)$$

written in `Physics.v` as trees of a deep expression language. Read at a free radius, with every radial derivative that of the Hermite reconstruction, they form the continuum residual. Let $X(s, u, v) =$

$(R \cos v, R \sin v, Z)$ be the reconstructed coordinate map, $\mathbf{e}_s$, $\mathbf{e}_u$ and $\mathbf{e}_v$ its partial derivatives, and $\mathbf{B} = B^u \mathbf{e}_u + B^v \mathbf{e}_v$ the reconstructed field as a function of (s, u, v) .

Theorem 1 (continuum_force_coords) *Let the slots of the residual's expressions hold a state's radii, coefficients, flux, transform and pressure derivative p' , and let (s_0, u_0, v_0) be a point where $\sqrt{g} \neq 0$. There let $\nabla s = \mathbf{e}_u \times \mathbf{e}_v / \sqrt{g}$, $\nabla u = \mathbf{e}_v \times \mathbf{e}_s / \sqrt{g}$ and $\nabla v = \mathbf{e}_s \times \mathbf{e}_u / \sqrt{g}$, and let $\partial_s \mathbf{B}$, $\partial_u \mathbf{B}$ and $\partial_v \mathbf{B}$ be the derivatives of $\mathbf{B}$ along the three coordinate lines through the point. Then the three outputs of the continuum residual there are $\mathbf{F} \cdot \mathbf{e}_s$, $\mathbf{F} \cdot \mathbf{e}_u$ and $\mathbf{F} \cdot \mathbf{e}_v$, with*

$$\mathbf{F} = (\nabla s \times \partial_s \mathbf{B} + \nabla u \times \partial_u \mathbf{B} + \nabla v \times \partial_v \mathbf{B}) \times \mathbf{B} - \mu_0 p' \nabla s. \quad (3)$$

The bracket is the curl of $\mathbf{B}$ in the coordinates $x^j = s, u, v$, since the Cartesian derivative of $\mathbf{B}$ is $\sum_j \nabla x^j \otimes \partial_j \mathbf{B}$. Every quantity in the statement is a formula in the reconstruction's derivatives at the point, and with $\nabla p = p' \nabla s$ the outputs are the covariant components of $\mu_0(\mathbf{J} \times \mathbf{B} - \nabla p)$. `continuum_force` gives the same outputs through the Cartesian curl: for any $\mathbf{G} : \mathbf{R}^3 \rightarrow \mathbf{R}^3$ and $P : \mathbf{R}^3 \rightarrow \mathbf{R}$ differentiable at $X(s_0, u_0, v_0)$ and equal to the reconstructed field and pressure along the three coordinate lines through it, they are $\mathbf{F} \cdot \mathbf{e}_i$ with $\mathbf{F} = (\nabla \times \mathbf{G}) \times \mathbf{G} - \mu_0 \nabla P$. `continuum_force_asym_coords` and `continuum_force_asym` are the two statements for a state without stellarator symmetry, and they rest on the identities at one point `Force.force_coords` and `Force.force_law`. At a node the solver's rule is used instead: the angular outputs are the formulas above at the outer half point, the radial output is VMEC's combination of the fields at the two half points, with centred differences for radial derivatives, and each of those fields is that of the series with VMEC's half-grid values and slopes (`node_residual`, `node_residual_asym`).

VMEC's products. Every half-point quantity that is linear in the coefficients, R , Z and their derivatives, agrees with VMEC's term for term. The Jacobian and the metric elements are products, which VMEC forms from averages over the two nodes of products of node values, where the reconstruction multiplies the interpolated series. `VmecKernel.v` transcribes VMEC++'s kernels and proves the differences exactly. With r, z the even parts and $\hat{r}, \hat{z}$ the odd parts divided by $\sqrt{s}$ of the node values, and Δ the outer node's value less the inner one's, the reconstruction's factor $R_u Z_s - R_s Z_u$ and VMEC's τ satisfy

$$(R_u Z_s - R_s Z_u) - \tau = -\frac{1}{8}(\Delta \hat{r}_u \Delta \hat{z} - \Delta \hat{z}_u \Delta \hat{r}) - \frac{1}{8\sqrt{s_h}}(\Delta r_u \Delta \hat{z} - \Delta z_u \Delta \hat{r}) \quad (4)$$

(`vmec_jacobian_difference`), and each of g_{uu} , g_{uv} and g_{vv} differs from VMEC's by a sum of such products (`vmec_metric_difference`). Where every node difference in the identity is at most $K|h|$, the two Jacobian factors agree to within $\frac{1}{4}(Kh)^2(1+s_h^{-1/2})$ (`vmec_jacobian_second_order`). The certified field is the reconstruction's, and VMEC's discrete field differs from it by these terms of second order in the radial step. They are small on the files of Section 4: evaluated in floating point (`gen/jacobian_gap.py`), the two Jacobians, and so the two $\sqrt{g}$ (`vmec_sqrtg_difference`), differ by at most a relative 1.1×10^{-6} on every half-grid surface whose nodes lie off the axis, and on the surfaces with $s \geq 1/4$ of Landreman's sheared equilibrium the difference falls from 6.3×10^{-7} at 13 surfaces to 1.2×10^{-9} at 200.

Identities. The representation builds some properties in, and for the reconstruction they are theorems: it is solenoidal (`divergence_free`), the $(0, 0)$ coefficient of λ drives nothing (`lambda_gauge`), which exhibits the poloidal relabelling as an exact kernel direction, and the residual has no component along the field (`residual_along_field`). The Euler–Lagrange expressions of VMEC's energy

$W = \int (B^2/2 - \mu_0 p) \sqrt{g}$ at fixed λ , ι , flux and pressure are $-\sqrt{g}$ times the cylindrical components of the force (`energy_gradient_is_force`), so that the forces the solver drives to zero are the ideal-MHD force. `Hypotheses.v` states the physical premises some theorems carry, such as nested flux surfaces and a scalar pressure, and the second-order bound `discretization_is_consistent` names, which `HalfGrid.v` derives from the proven consistency of the node rule and a stability bound (Section 4).

3 Certificates and their soundness

A certificate is a text file that a generator in `gen/` writes from a wout file. It carries every number of the file it uses as an integer mantissa and a power-of-two exponent, so no rounding happens between the file and the certificate, together with the bounds it claims; the extracted checker recomputes every enclosure from those numbers, and no bound the generator computes is trusted.

Expressions and intervals. `Expr.v` gives an expression two meanings: a value over extended reals, in which division by zero and the square root of a negative number give `Xnan`, and a value over CoqInterval’s floating-point intervals. `ieval_correct` states that the interval contains the extended-real value, so a bounded output interval proves both that the value is a real number and that it lies in the bounds. Because the embedding is deep, one tree carries both meanings, `Deriv.v` differentiates it symbolically with a chain rule proven in the extended-real sense, and subexpressions that the residual’s components share are bound once to environment slots.

Verdicts. A point certificate bounds the residual at points (`check_cert_correct`). A cell certificate bounds a component over a rectangle of two varied slots, two angles or an angle and the radius, by its value at the centre plus enclosures of its derivatives over the rectangle times the half-widths (`check_ccert_correct`); reversed, the same data bounds a component away from zero. The bound tightens as the cells shrink, since each derivative enclosure is taken over its own cell: on one surface of the Solov’ev equilibrium, where the residual reaches 4.1×10^{-7} in floating point, the bound falls from 2.2×10^3 with 8 cells to 7.7×10^{-6} with 8192, about sixteen-fold per fourfold refinement from 128 cells on. `Cover2.v` decides, column by column, that the cells of a verdict cover the rectangle they span (`cells_cover_rect`) or every line they lie on (`cells_cover_lines`). A spectral solution balances forces mode by mode, so the quantity it makes small is the discrete Fourier harmonic of the residual at a retained mode, which `Project.v` encloses (`harm_encloses`); `Harmonic.v` integrates exactly the components whose trigonometric degree lies below an equispaced grid’s point counts, and `Integrate.v` encloses other flux-surface integrals by the midpoint rule over a lattice of cells that the checker lays out itself, with the error read off its own enclosures of the second derivatives over each cell (`integ2_correct`, `integ1_correct`). `MercierRun.v` assembles DShear, DCurr, DWell, DGeod and DMerc as VMEC’s `mercier.f90` defines them [10, 11] from integrals over the whole angular torus that the same run computes: the lattice reaches past each period of 2π , the period ends inside its last cells, and the two strips it adds are bounded through the integrand’s enclosures over those cells (`integ2_torus_correct`). A verdict is then a theorem about the criterion of the reconstruction (`merc_run_correct`). In `Box.v` every input slot carries a half-width, so one evaluation covers every field whose coefficients lie in a box. The theorem behind the resonant harmonic of Section 4 shows the form every soundness theorem takes:

```
Theorem dharm_correct :
  forall c, check_dharm c = true ->
    forall xs, in_box (hc_ms c) (hc_ds c) xs ->
```

Check	Size	Time
points, free-boundary jump	NESTOR’s grid	0.1–5 s
points, $\mathbf{B} - \mathbf{B}^*$ of Landreman’s field	64×32 points	4–30 s
cells, Solov’ev residual on a surface	8–8192 cells	up to 16 s
cells, free-boundary jump over the boundary	512×128 cells per period	48 and 68 min
harmonic over a box of states, binary64	64×32 points	3 s
harmonic, rows at 256 bits	64×32 points	2.0–2.6 h
Mercier criterion	four coverings of 2048 cells	3 min
Newton existence, 120 or 128 bits	up to 423 unknowns	up to 44 min
stability on the same box	423 unknowns	26 min
W7-X points and projection	4096 points, 288–800 modes	21 min–2.8 h

Table 1: Time to check certificates on a laptop (Intel i9-12900H) with four worker processes, most of them beside three other checks.

```
contains (I.convert (harm_total c))
  (Xreal (dsum2 (hc_Nu c) (hc_Nv c) 0 0 (harm_fun c xs))).
```

For a certificate c whose check passes and every state $\mathbf{x}s$ in its box, the equispaced sum of the component times the harmonic’s kernel over the certificate’s grid of angles is a real number, and it lies in the interval `harm_total c` that the same computation returns.

Discrete equilibria. `Newton.v` proves that a passing interval Newton test in Krawczyk form [12, 13] on any system of expressions gives exactly one zero in its box: $x - AF(x)$ maps the box into itself as a contraction, and an approximate inverse A makes its fixed point a zero of F . `Colloc.v` collocates the residual over a band of surfaces as such a system, with the surface coefficients as unknowns (`colloc_correct`), and `Wide.v` evaluates the system’s outputs at the centre of the box in floating point of any precision.

Trust base. The kernel checks the proofs; what runs is the OCaml extraction of the checking functions, linked with a driver that parses certificates into the extracted data types, divides the checking among processes and prints verdicts. The trusted components are the Rocq kernel and extraction, the OCaml toolchain, the implementation of Rocq’s primitive 63-bit integers and binary64 floats, the driver’s parser and its division of the work, and the correspondence between a certificate’s numbers and the output or formulas they are taken from, which `gen/verify_cert.py` checks for a wout file. The classical constructions behind Rocq’s real numbers appear only in specifications, and extraction directives replace them by values that fail when consulted. The theorems named here rest on the two axioms of the standard library’s classical Dedekind reals, excluded middle, functional extensionality and the specifications of the primitive operations. The build pins Rocq 9.1.1 with its standard library 9.2.0, CoqInterval 4.11.4, Flocq 4.2.2, Coquelicot 3.4.5, MathComp 2.4.0 and OCaml 4.14.2.

Cost. Checking takes seconds to hours on a laptop (Table 1). A point certificate evaluates the residual once per point, a cell certificate its derivatives over each cell and a harmonic every point of its grid, so the cost grows with the number of modes, with the number of points or cells, and with the precision: a harmonic whose rows are evaluated at 256 bits in software floating point takes hours where the same harmonic in binary64 takes seconds. The checker divides a certificate’s points, cells or rows among processes.

4 Results

Table 2 collects the certified results with the theorem each rests on. The manufactured problems are Stellarocq’s collocated systems for the manufactured mappings of the VMEC++ pull request [29] that adds a force source to the solver, and every other case is a VMEC++ run or a file from its test data. The runs of Landreman’s equilibrium, of the rippled tokamak and of W7-X are VMEC++ 0.4.7, and the free-boundary and Mercier runs the branch of [28], which reads NESTOR’s vacuum field. A number called certified is an enclosure that a passing verdict proves, rounded outward.

The order of the half-grid rule. Away from the axis the half-grid rule converges at second order, and on manufactured problems its error is known to twelve digits. `HalfGrid.v` proves the node rule second-order consistent with the residual of the continuously reconstructed field (`node_consistent`); near the axis, where the innermost interval is read linearly, the rule is first order in the radial derivatives. Manufactured solutions [15] measure the order. The mappings are the $m \leq 1$ ones of the manufactured-solution test of [29], with three field periods. The three-dimensional one is $R = 1 + p_0 s + p_1 s^2 - 0.005 \cos 3\phi + \sqrt{s} (0.05 \cos u + 0.005 \cos(u - 3\phi))$ and $Z = 0.005 \sin 3\phi + \sqrt{s} (0.05 \sin u - 0.005 \sin(u - 3\phi))$ with $p_0 = -3.32 \times 10^{-4}$ and $p_1 = -8.06 \times 10^{-6}$, $\iota = 0.42 + 0.13s$, $p = 1.6 \times 10^5 (1 - s)$ Pa and a stream function with harmonics up to $m = 2$, and the one without stellarator symmetry adds $0.004 \sin 3\phi + \sqrt{s} (0.006 \sin u + 0.002 \sin u \cos 3\phi)$ to R and $0.003 \cos 3\phi + \sqrt{s} (0.006 \cos u + 0.002 \cos u \cos 3\phi)$ to Z . The file that defines them, `examples/manufactured_solution.py` of that pull request at commit `fbdb696`, is copied into Stellarocq’s `gen/`, and the generator reads every constant of the problem from it. A manufactured mapping on the annulus $1/4 < s < 1$ is not an equilibrium; its continuum residual at the collocation points is a source f , and the zero x_h of $r - f$ over the interior nodes, with λ given so that the problem sits on the quotient by the poloidal gauge, is the discrete solution. Every datum of the problem, the coefficients it holds fixed, λ , the transform and the source, is the mapping’s own value carried to 120 bits. On systems of up to 423 unknowns the interval Newton test puts exactly one zero in a box a few units of a 58-bit mantissa wide in each unknown, around a centre refined on outputs read at 128 bits, so the error $\max |x_h - x^*|$ is enclosed to within 5×10^{-20} , a relative 10^{-12} (Table 2). It falls by 3.81, 3.92 and 3.97 per doubling for the three-dimensional mapping and by 3.73 and 3.87 for the one without stellarator symmetry (Figure 1a). Its enclosures are identical at five times the pressure, which enters the radial force only as a flux function that the rule and its source share, and the same problem with its data rounded to binary64 has an error that differs in the eighth digit.

Convergence also needs stability. Given a constant S , the same at every radial step, with $|x_h - x^*| \leq S |r(x^*) - f|$, the theorem `lax_second_order` turns consistency into the second-order bound that `discretization_is_consistent` states. For the three-dimensional problem, $S_h = \|J_h^{-1}\|_\infty$ at x^* , with J_h the Jacobian of the forced residual, is 0.0438 at 9 surfaces and 0.0555 at 1025 in floating point, each doubling from 65 surfaces on adding half as much as the one before, so that it tends to about 0.056, while the consistency residual $|r(x^*) - f|$ falls from 1.9×10^{-3} to 3.6×10^{-7} (`gen/stability_scan.py`). The hypothesis holds with one constant at every resolution measured, and it remains a hypothesis beyond them. The collocated system is the half-grid residual of the reconstruction at collocation points. VMEC’s own discrete equations come from the variation of the energy with spectral condensation and a constraint on the $m = 1$ modes, and they form the Jacobian and metric from the products whose difference from the reconstruction’s `VmecKernel.v` gives exactly, at second order in h . The annulus keeps the axis, where the rule is first order, out of the problem; the first-order radial convergence that [16] report for VMEC is that of the force error of VMEC’s own solutions averaged over $0.1 \leq s \leq 0.99$ of a discrete problem that contains the axis.

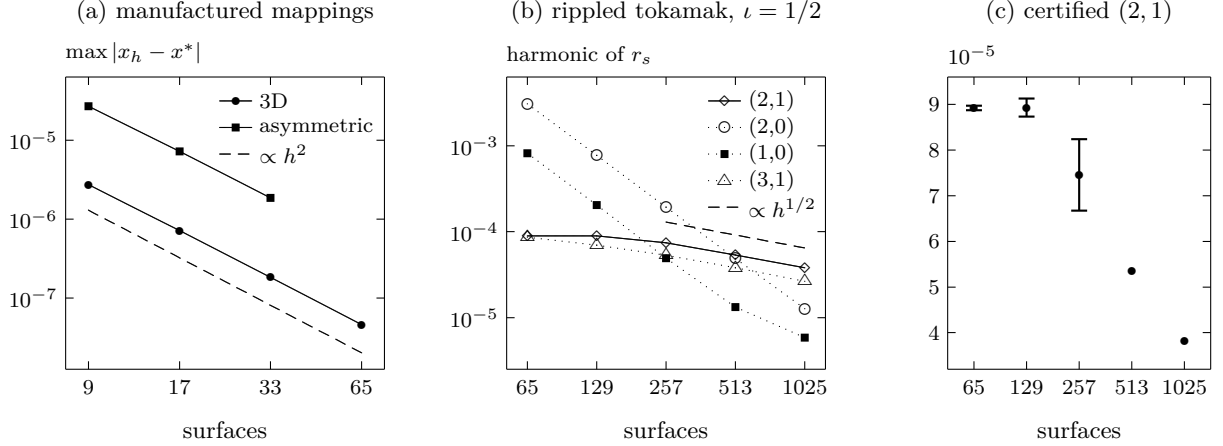


Figure 1: (a) The certified error of the half-grid scheme on the manufactured mappings; the dashed line falls as h^2 . (b) Harmonics of the radial force r_s on the surface $\iota = 1/2$ of the rippled tokamak: the resonant (2,1) harmonic, certified at 256 bits, and the floating-point (2,0), (1,0) and (3,1) harmonics of the same reconstruction; the dashed line falls as $h^{1/2}$. (c) The (2,1) harmonic on a linear scale: its binary64 enclosures at 65, 129 and 257 surfaces, and its 256-bit enclosures, narrower than the dots, at 65 to 1025.

On an equilibrium the collocated system has solutions as well: one, two and three surfaces of the Solov’ev equilibrium [14] each have exactly one zero of the collocated residual in a box of radius 6.0×10^{-10} to 7.7×10^{-9} around a centre that Newton’s method moved 1.8×10^{-6} to 3.0×10^{-6} from the file’s coefficients.

A forced current sheet. At a rational surface the discrete solution converges more slowly than anywhere else: the resonant harmonic of the force falls as the square root of the radial step. On VMEC++’s circular tokamak ($R_0 = 6$, $a = 2$) with $\iota = 0.9 - 0.64s$, which is $1/2$ at $s = 0.625$, and a (1,1) boundary ripple of amplitude 0.03, toroidal coupling drives a (2,1) harmonic of the radial force on the rational surface. Its certified value is the rectangle rule for the integral of $r_s \cos(2u - v)$ on a 64×32 grid of angles, in T^2 like r_s , against $1.2 \times 10^3 T^2$ for the integral of B^2 there. With each row of the grid evaluated and summed at 256 bits, `wdharm_b_correct` encloses it at the converged states of 65 to 1025 surfaces to within a relative 2×10^{-12} (Table 2, Figure 1c), and it is linear in the ripple. After a rise of 0.11 per cent from 65 to 129 surfaces it falls by 1.20, 1.39 and 1.41 per doubling, approaching the factor $\sqrt{2}$ of a decay as $h^{1/2}$, while the axisymmetric harmonics (2,0) and (1,0) of the same reconstruction fall about fourfold per doubling in floating point, and the (3,1) sideband 1.24 to 1.44-fold (Figure 1b). The same ripple on a transform profile with no low-order rational surface nearby leaves nothing behind.

The slow fall comes from the shape of the harmonic across the surfaces. In floating point it forms a layer about the rational surface, positive inside it and negative outside. The layer’s extremes stay of order $10^{-4} T^2$ while its width shrinks only as $h^{1/2}$, from 0.156 to 0.033 in s between 65 and 1025 surfaces, and its zero lies a fixed 2.4 to 3.9 radial steps outside the rational surface, so the value on that surface, the layer’s slope times the offset, falls as $h^{1/2}$. This is the response of a nested-surface field at a rational surface [17, 18, 19], whose ideal limit is a current sheet and which [20] studied in VMEC; three-dimensional equilibria with current sheets and stepped pressure exist [21, 22]. SPEC [23] makes the sheet explicit. With two Beltrami volumes separated by an ideal interface at

the rational surface it is a jump of 1.47×10^{-5} in the covariant poloidal field at ripple 0.03, as in the equilibria of [24], and with the rational surface inside a relaxed volume SPEC’s field-line tracing finds a (2, 1) island whose width grows from 0.107 to 0.173 in the volume’s radial coordinate as the ripple goes from 0.0075 to 0.03, as the ripple to the power 0.35.

The certified conclusion does not depend on the file’s last digits or on the converged state being exact. In binary64 interval arithmetic (`dharm_correct`) the harmonic lies between 5.8×10^{-5} and 9.4×10^{-5} for every state within a relative 10^{-14} of the converged coefficients at 65, 129 and 257 surfaces; these enclosures widen about fourfold per doubling, from 1.1 to 21 per cent of the value, as second radial differences amplify the rounding by h^{-2} . On the rational surface the collocated Newton test, its centre refined on outputs read at 128 bits, certifies a discrete solution at 33 and at 65 surfaces, where the Jacobian’s condition number is 1.4×10^6 and 3.0×10^6 in floating point.

Free-boundary balance. At the free boundary the balance VMEC++ imposes leaves a pressure jump that radial refinement barely reduces. At a free-boundary equilibrium $\mu_0 p + B^2/2$ is continuous across the plasma boundary, where outside it is the pressure of the full vacuum field. VMEC++ computes that field with NESTOR [25, 2], and BIEST’s virtual-casing field [26, 27] gives it independently. The certificate sweeps the vacuum pressure over the segment between the two answers, $P_{\text{vac}} = P_{\text{mid}} + t \delta P$ with $t \in [-1, 1]$, and takes the plasma side as VMEC’s extrapolation of the two outermost half points to $s = 1$. The sweep variable is a slot of the box, which `check_bpcert_correct` and `check_btcert_correct` quantify over separately at each point and in each cell, so every statement below holds for each vacuum pressure whose value at each point lies between the two answers there.

On the CTH-like test case, where $B^2/2$ averages 0.18 T^2 on the boundary, the largest jump on NESTOR’s grid is enclosed in $[7.556, 7.561] \times 10^{-4} \text{ T}^2$ at 25 surfaces and in $[4.9647, 4.9673] \times 10^{-4} \text{ T}^2$ at 385 (Table 2). Each enclosure lies below the one before it, so the jump does fall, but only by 1.05 to 1.14 per doubling of the surfaces. The two answers differ by up to $6.1 \times 10^{-4} \text{ T}^2$ on the grid, and with the sweep widened to five times that difference the largest jump is at most $1.89 \times 10^{-3} \text{ T}^2$, a hundredth of $B^2/2$, at every resolution. Covered over the whole boundary by 512×128 cells per field period, with the vacuum side the trigonometric interpolant of each answer’s grid, the jump is at most $8.47 \times 10^{-3} \text{ T}^2$ at 25 surfaces and 1.051×10^{-2} at 385. Between grid points that interpolant sets the bound, and radial refinement leaves its angular resolution as it is.

The jump lies almost wholly beyond the Fourier harmonics through which VMEC imposes the balance. In floating point at 49 surfaces its part in the retained harmonics is at most $2.4 \times 10^{-5} \text{ T}^2$ and the rest 7.2×10^{-4} ; the retained part falls 3.3 and 1.9-fold per doubling from 25 to 97 surfaces, while with NESTOR’s poloidal grid fixed, retaining 5 to 12 poloidal harmonics moves the jump between 4.0×10^{-4} and 1.5×10^{-3} without reducing it.

The Mercier criterion at coarse resolution. At coarse radial resolution the sign of the Mercier criterion depends on how its radial derivatives are taken, and the certificates prove both signs. At $s = 0.125$ of `up_down_asym` on 17 surfaces, with 2048 poloidal cells, the criterion of the Hermite reconstruction is certified unstable: DMerc lies in $[-1.371, -1.205] \times 10^{-3}$ and the current term in $[-3.724, -3.716] \times 10^{-3}$, where the file’s own difference quotients give a stable $+1.8 \times 10^{-3}$ and a current term of -6.1×10^{-4} . `MercierFile.v` takes the four flux-function derivatives from the file’s centred differences of its half-grid profiles instead, each an exact dyadic, and integrates the same angular integrands (`merc_run_q_correct`): DMerc then lies in $[1.711, 1.875] \times 10^{-3}$, which contains the file’s value. The two certified answers differ only in the radial derivatives, so at 17 surfaces those set the sign. From 33 to 257 surfaces both current terms tend to zero with the file’s

sign, the certified one from $[-1.092, -1.083] \times 10^{-3}$ to $[-3.7, -1.8] \times 10^{-5}$, and the certified DMerc is positive at each.

An exact equilibrium. Landreman’s families [58] are three-dimensional equilibria with nested flux surfaces whose field $\mathbf{B}^*$ and flux label ψ^* are elementary functions of the Cartesian position, so a solver’s distance from them is a true error. `Landreman.v` and `LandremanSheared.v` prove that both consist of ideal-MHD equilibria: the family with $\iota = 2$ for all positive semiaxes wherever the radicand of $\mathbf{B}^*$ is positive, and the sheared family for all positive ϵ and λ and every S wherever (x, y) lies off the segment $x = 0, |y| \leq \sqrt{\epsilon}$. In each the field is solenoidal (`iota2_divergence`, `sheared_divergence`), satisfies $(\nabla \times \mathbf{B}) \times \mathbf{B} = \nabla p$ with $p = p_a - 2\psi$ and $p = p_a - \psi/\lambda^2$ respectively (`iota2_force`, `sheared_force`), and is tangent to the level sets of p (`iota2_tangent`, `sheared_tangent`). Two outputs of the checker compare the reconstruction with a member of either family: the cylindrical components of $\mathbf{B} - \mathbf{B}^*(X)$ on a half-grid surface, with $\mathbf{B}$ the reconstructed field and X its position, and $\psi^*(X)$ on a node surface. `LandremanExact.v` proves that the expressions behind those outputs evaluate to the field and flux label of `Landreman.v` and of `LandremanSheared.v` on those domains (`exact_b_iota2`, `exact_b_sheared`).

Against the sheared family VMEC++’s field converges at about second order away from the axis. Its solution of the member with $\epsilon = 0.6$, $S = 2.2$, $\lambda = 2.97$ and $k_b = 0.2$, whose transform runs from 4.34 to 4.37, at 13 to 200 surfaces with $m \leq 11$ and $|n| \leq 10$, is certified at every point of a 64×32 grid of a field period on its innermost, middle and outermost half-grid surfaces, where $|\mathbf{B}^*|$ lies between 0.30 and 0.38 T (Table 2). On the middle and outermost surfaces the largest component of $\mathbf{B} - \mathbf{B}^*$ falls from 1.32×10^{-5} and 8.25×10^{-6} T at 13 surfaces to 2.53×10^{-8} and 2.12×10^{-8} T at 200, by 3.5 to 5.6 per doubling. The innermost surface moves toward the axis as the surfaces double, from $s = 0.125$ to 0.008, and there the difference falls only from 2.94×10^{-5} to 3.34×10^{-6} T. At the points of the same grid the outermost node surface lies within 2.32×10^{-7} of a level set of ψ^* at 13 surfaces and within 1.71×10^{-10} at 200, where ψ^* is 0.02 on the boundary.

Against the member with $\iota = 2$, whose every surface is rational, VMEC++’s field does not converge. In floating point its distance from $\mathbf{B}^*$ at mid-radius is 8.4×10^{-4} , 2.3×10^{-4} , 1.9×10^{-3} and 1.9×10^{-4} T at 13, 25, 50 and 100 surfaces, with 77 to 86 per cent of its spectral power in the resonant harmonics. Those bend no field line when $\iota = 2$ on every surface, so VMEC’s energy is flat along them and nothing in the discrete problem fixes their amplitude.

An optimized stellarator. On W7-X the certified force is set by the Fourier truncation and not by the radial grid. VMEC++’s solution of W7-X from its test data, at a volume-averaged β of 4.0 per cent with $m \leq 11$ and toroidal numbers up to 12 per field period, converged to $f_{sqr} < 10^{-12}$ at 49, 97 and 193 surfaces, is certified at every point of a 64×64 grid of a field period on the surfaces $s = 1/4, 1/2$ and $3/4$ (`check_cert_correct`), and the same verdicts enclose the discrete harmonics of each component there at the 288 modes VMEC++ retains (`harm_encloses`). At every resolution the largest component of $\mu_0(\mathbf{J} \times \mathbf{B} - \nabla p)$ is close to 7.7×10^{-2} T², about a hundredth of B^2 , and the largest harmonic at a retained mode close to 5.5×10^{-4} T², at $m = 10$, next to the edge of the retained band (Table 2). Raising the angular resolution does what doubling the surfaces does not: at 49 surfaces with $m \leq 15$ and $m \leq 19$, toroidal numbers up to 16 and 20, the largest component is at most 5.72 and 3.84×10^{-2} T² and the largest retained harmonic at most 3.66 and 1.51×10^{-4} T².

Use in VMEC++. The certified values are regression tests on a branch of VMEC++ [28], whose tolerances are the enclosures: the manufactured-solution errors, the resonant harmonic with the fall of the axisymmetric harmonics, and the free-boundary jump, which reads NESTOR’s bound-

ary vacuum field through an option proposed upstream [30]. A finite difference of VMEC++’s energy equals its unpreconditioned forces contracted with the perturbation, the discrete form of `energy_gradient_is_force`; VMEC++ now tests this [31], and that the energy Hessian is symmetric and DGeod never positive [32]. Its continuous integration now runs VMEC++ on members of both of Landreman’s families on every change and measures, in floating point, its flux surfaces, magnetic axis, field and enclosed current against the exact ones [33]. Differential tests of VMEC++ for invariances the reconstruction satisfies exactly, three of which VMEC++ now runs [34], also exposed an orientation test that the poloidal rotation VMEC applies to an asymmetric boundary can defeat: the test multiplies two $m = 1$ coefficients whose product the rotation can drive to zero, where the invariant is the $m = 1$ determinant $r^{cc}z^{sc} - r^{sc}z^{cc}$. Relabelling the `up_down_asym_current` boundary by $\theta \rightarrow \pi - \theta$ sends educational_VMEC to its iteration cap at $f_{sqr} = 2.07 \times 10^{-2}$ instead of converging to 5.07×10^{-12} . It was reported as vmecpp#788 [35], after which VMEC++ tests the determinant [36], and as educational_VMEC#27 [37].

5 Consequences for users of VMEC

A converged run does not certify its field. VMEC’s normalized force residual measures the Fourier harmonics the solver retains, and the force of the field its file defines can stay far above it: W7-X converged to $f_{sqr} < 10^{-12}$ carries a force near a hundredth of B^2 at points of its surfaces, and neither that force nor its largest retained harmonic falls as the surfaces double, while both fall as the poloidal and toroidal resolution rises. A convergence study of a stellarator equilibrium therefore has to vary the angular resolution as well as the number of surfaces, and a quantity computed from the field at points inherits an error that the angular truncation sets and the residual does not report.

Radial convergence away from rational surfaces says little about their neighbourhood. Near a low-order rational surface the discrete solution forms a current layer whose resonant force harmonic falls only as $h^{1/2}$, so an equilibrium with such a surface in the plasma converges there far more slowly than elsewhere, and where every surface is rational, as in Landreman’s family with $\iota = 2$, the solution does not converge at all. At coarse radial resolution a quantity built from radial derivatives of the profiles can change sign with the way the derivatives are taken: at 17 surfaces the Mercier criterion of `up_down_asym` is certified unstable for the reconstruction and stable for the file’s own differences, and from 33 surfaces on the certified criterion is stable. A Mercier sign near marginal stability from a coarse run is worth confirming at more surfaces.

At a free boundary the pressure balance does not improve with radial resolution. The jump of $\mu_0 p + B^2/2$ against the vacuum pressure on the CTH-like boundary falls only from 7.6 to $5.0 \times 10^{-4} \text{ T}^2$, a few thousandths of $B^2/2$, as the surfaces go from 25 to 385, and retaining more poloidal harmonics on NESTOR’s fixed grid moves it without reducing it. The residual, harmonic and Mercier checks run on any wout file, in seconds for points and hours for harmonics at 256 bits (Table 1).

6 Related work

Rigorous numerics proves statements about dynamical systems and partial differential equations with interval arithmetic: the existence of the Lorenz attractor [38], the CAPD library for ordinary differential equations [39], KAM theory applied by computer [40], among other systems to magnetic field lines [41], blow-up of the Boussinesq and axisymmetric Euler equations [42], and elliptic and parabolic problems [43], among them the existence of stationary Navier–Stokes flows

in three-dimensional domains near a computed approximation [44]. These proofs run in libraries outside a proof assistant. Inside one, verified ODE solvers up to the Lorenz attractor [45, 46], the discretization and floating-point program of the one-dimensional wave equation [47], the Lax–Milgram theorem [48] and simplicial Lagrange finite elements [49] in Rocq, and the certificates of the Kepler conjecture [50] come closest; in Lean, high-energy physics is being formalized [51] and a formalization has found an error in the literature on the stability of the two-Higgs-doublet potential [52], the characterization of the equilibria of the Vlasov–Maxwell–Landau system has been formalized [53], and smooth magnetohydrostatic equilibria with nested pressure surfaces and only a discrete rotational symmetry, counterexamples to Grad’s conjecture [17], come with a Lean certification [54]. In fusion, formal methods have verified a plasma vertical-position control algorithm [55] and properties of neural surrogates of the Grad–Shafranov equation [56]. Stellarator equilibrium codes are verified by convergence studies, manufactured solutions and comparison between codes, VMEC against SPEC [23, 24, 20] and against DESC [57, 16], and against Landreman’s explicit three-dimensional equilibria [58], whose supplement solves them in DESC. We know of no prior work that states the output of a stellarator equilibrium code as a machine-checked theorem about the field it defines.

7 Conclusion

Stellarocq gives the output of an equilibrium code a meaning a proof assistant can check: bounds, harmonics, stability terms and the existence of discrete solutions, each a theorem about the field reconstructed from the file’s exact numbers, whose residual is proven to be the ideal-MHD force. Its verdicts are regression tests on a branch of VMEC++ whose tolerances are the certified enclosures. Against Landreman’s explicit equilibria [58], both of whose families the development proves to be ideal-MHD equilibria, the same certificates measure a solver’s error against a true equilibrium rather than a manufactured one, a comparison VMEC++ now makes in floating point on every change [33].

Availability. The development, the certificate generators and the script that writes Figure 1 are at <https://github.com/CharlesCNorton/stellarocq>, commit 18b64aa; `make all` builds the proofs and the checker, the release `checker-18b64aa` carries the same checker linked statically for x86_64 Linux with the certificates behind the results and their SHA-256 sums, and each generator’s documentation gives the commands of its result. The VMEC++ tests that carry the certified values are on the branch of [28].

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Case	Certified quantity	Enclosure
manufactured, 3D	$\max x_h - x^* $, 9/17/33/65 surfaces colloc_correct	$2.73432936829 \times 10^{-6}$, $7.16912170772 \times 10^{-7}$, $1.83032585742 \times 10^{-7}$, $4.6074819334 \times 10^{-8}$
manufactured, asymmetric	$\max x_h - x^* $, 9/17/33 surfaces colloc_correct	$2.69073057043 \times 10^{-5}$, $7.20667053290 \times 10^{-6}$, $1.86266877703 \times 10^{-6}$
Solov'ev, 1–3 surfaces	zero of the collocated residual colloc_correct	exactly one, in boxes of radius 6.0×10^{-10} to 7.7×10^{-9}
rippled tokamak, $\iota = 1/2$ at $s = 0.625$	(2, 1) harmonic of r_s at the converged state, 65/129/257/513/1025 surfaces, at 256 bits wdharm_b_correct ; over a box of relative width 10^{-14} , 65/129/257 surfaces dharm_correct	8.9208, 8.9310, 7.4567, 5.3557 and $3.8084 \times 10^{-5} \text{ T}^2$, each to a relative 2×10^{-12} ; over the box [8.81, 9.03], [8.51, 9.35], $[5.80, 9.11] \times 10^{-5} \text{ T}^2$
CTH-like, free boundary	largest jump of $\mu_0 p + B^2/2$ against $B_{\text{vac}}^2/2$ on NESTOR's grid, 25/49/97/193/385 surfaces check_bpcert_correct	[7.556, 7.561], [7.201, 7.206], [6.433, 6.437], [5.636, 5.640] and $[4.9647, 4.9673] \times 10^{-4} \text{ T}^2$, for every vacuum pressure between NESTOR's and BIEST's
CTH-like, free boundary	the same jump over the whole boundary, 25/385 surfaces check_btcert_correct	at most $8.47 \times 10^{-3} \text{ T}^2$, at most $1.051 \times 10^{-2} \text{ T}^2$
CTH-like, free boundary	the largest jump on NESTOR's grid for every vacuum pressure within five times the two answers' disagreement, 25/49/97/193/385 surfaces check_bpcert_correct	at most 1.87, 1.89, 1.81, 1.73 and $1.66 \times 10^{-3} \text{ T}^2$
up_down_asym, $s = 0.125$, 17 surfaces	Mercier current term and DMerc merc_run_correct	$[-3.724, -3.716] \times 10^{-3}$ and $[-1.371, -1.205] \times 10^{-3}$, where the file gives -6.1×10^{-4} and $+1.8 \times 10^{-3}$ in floating point
up_down_asym, $s = 0.125$, 17 surfaces	the same with the file's centred radial differences merc_run_q_correct	$[-6.421, -6.366] \times 10^{-4}$ and $[1.711, 1.875] \times 10^{-3}$
Landreman's sheared equilibrium, 13/25/50/100/200 surfaces	largest component of $\mathbf{B} - \mathbf{B}^*$ at a 64×32 grid of a field period on the innermost, middle and outermost half-grid surfaces check_bpcert_correct	2.94×10^{-5} , 1.32×10^{-5} , 8.25×10^{-6} ; 1.36×10^{-5} , 2.93×10^{-6} , 2.00×10^{-6} ; 5.61×10^{-6} , 5.39×10^{-7} , 5.67×10^{-7} ; 4.35×10^{-6} , 1.12×10^{-7} , 1.02×10^{-7} ; 3.34×10^{-6} , 2.53×10^{-8} , $2.12 \times 10^{-8} \text{ T}$, where $ \mathbf{B}^* $ is 0.30 to 0.38 T
Landreman's sheared equilibrium, 13/25/50/100/200 surfaces	spread of ψ^* about a level set at a 64×32 grid of a field period on the outermost node surface check_bpcert_correct	2.32×10^{-7} , 4.95×10^{-8} , 1.77×10^{-8} , 1.70×10^{-9} and 1.71×10^{-10} , where ψ^* is 0.02 on the boundary
W7-X, $\beta = 4$ per cent, 49/97/193 surfaces	largest component of $\mu_0(\mathbf{J} \times \mathbf{B} - \nabla p)$ at a 64×64 grid of a field period on the surfaces $s = 1/4, 1/2, 3/4$ check_cert_correct ; the largest of its discrete harmonics at the 288 retained modes harm_encloses	at most 7.71, 7.73, $7.82 \times 10^{-2} \text{ T}^2$; at most 5.49, 5.49, $5.46 \times 10^{-4} \text{ T}^2$, where B^2 is about 7 T^2